

Ideation Phase

Brainstorming & Idea Prioritization

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1. Purpose

The ideation phase converts the project need described in the ServiceNow guide into a practical solution concept. The focus is on structured spreadsheet import, controlled transformation, duplicate prevention, and visibility through reports and a dashboard.

2. Problem Areas Identified

Area	Observed Need	Project Relevance
Data intake	Employee information arrives as structured spreadsheet data.	Requires a repeatable import mechanism.
Staging	Imported rows need an intermediate location before transformation.	ServiceNow Import Set table provides the staging layer.
Mapping	Spreadsheet columns must correspond to target employee fields.	Transform Map performs source-to-target mapping.
Duplicate handling	Repeated employee data should not create unnecessary duplicates.	Coalesce is used to match and update existing records.
Visibility	Imported data needs simple reporting and consolidated viewing.	Three reports and an Employee Analytics Dashboards dashboard are created.

3. Brainstormed Solution Options

Idea	Description	Fit to Guide
Manual record entry	Enter employee records one by one in the target table.	Low: does not address bulk spreadsheet import.
Direct spreadsheet-to-target entry	Attempt to load spreadsheet data directly into the final table.	Partial: misses the staging and transformation workflow.
Import Set + Transform Map	Stage spreadsheet rows, map fields, transform into Employee Test.	Directly supported by the project guide.
Import + Coalesce	Add matching logic so repeated employee IDs update existing rows.	Directly supported by the guide.
Import + Reporting + Dashboard	Add department/location/list reports and combine them on a dashboard.	Directly supported by the guide.

4. Prioritization Logic

The project concept is organized around the workflow explicitly demonstrated in the guide. The selected implementation therefore centers on Import Sets and Transform Maps, then extends the workflow with Coalesce, reports, and a dashboard.

5. Selected Concept

A ServiceNow-based employee data import workflow in which spreadsheet data is loaded into an Import Set, mapped through a Transform Map into the Employee Test table, matched through Coalesce where configured, and presented through reports and the Employee Analytics Dashboards dashboard.

1.1 Project Context

The project is centered on a practical ServiceNow data-management problem: employee information is prepared externally in spreadsheet form and then brought into ServiceNow. The ideation process therefore considers not only how to load the data, but also how to stage it, map it, transform it, validate it, handle repeated imports, and present the resulting records in a useful way.

1.2 Brainstorming Questions

The brainstorming activity considered several questions: What should happen when a spreadsheet is received? Where should source rows be stored before they become final records? How should source columns be connected to target columns? How can an existing employee be recognized during a later import? How can the imported information be checked after transformation? How can the resulting records be summarized for users?

1.3 Idea Evaluation Criteria

Ideas were considered against four project-specific criteria: alignment with the ServiceNow guide, suitability for structured spreadsheet data, ability to support repeated imports, and ability to provide visible validation. These criteria naturally lead to the Import Set and Transform Map workflow described in the project guide.

1.4 Detailed Prioritization Rationale

The Import Set approach is central because the guide explicitly uses Employee Import as an intermediate table. The Transform Map is equally central because it defines how source fields reach Employee Test. Coalesce is treated as an enhancement to the basic workflow because it becomes important when the same employee information is imported again. Reporting and the dashboard are positioned after successful data transformation because they depend on reliable target-table records.

1.5 Ideation Outcome

The ideation phase results in one coherent solution rather than several disconnected features: prepare spreadsheet data, stage it, transform it, match existing records where required, verify the outcome, and provide reports/dashboard visibility. This gives the later requirement and design phases a clear foundation.